

IDAHO OWNER-BUILDER PERMIT KIT

The building permit is optional · The trade permits are not

Project Address: _____

City / Town: _____

County: _____

Building Permit From: _____

Trade Permits From: _____

Health District No.: _____

Owner-Builder: _____

"Building Permit From" may honestly read NONE. "Trade Permits From" never does.
Write DOPL, or the city or county that runs its own program — ID.1 shows you how to tell.

Every Idaho statute, rule and requirement in this kit
is cited on the page it appears on — verified September 2026.

BUILD YOUR HOUSE

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First Edition — 2026

How to Use This Kit

Five working documents, from "does anyone permit my house?" to the last inspection tag.

Idaho's Building Code Act does not impose a building permit on a private house. It **authorizes** each city and county to adopt and enforce a building code, and the state Division of Occupational and Professional Licenses (DOPL) enforces the Act only for the buildings the Act puts under the state — state-owned buildings, public schools, modular and manufactured units. Where your county or city has adopted no ordinance, there is **no residential building permit, no plan review, no building inspection and no certificate of occupancy**. DOPL's own plan-review form says it in one line: "DOPL does NOT issue building permits for projects not owned by the State."

That is the half everybody knows. The other half is the reason this kit exists. **Three permits survive that gap, and each one is statewide:** an electrical permit, a plumbing permit and an HVAC permit — from DOPL wherever no city or county runs its own program — plus the health-district septic permit and the IDWR well drilling permit, which never depended on the building code at all. The electrical permit is enforced at the meter: by statute your power supplier, rural co-op included, may not energize the house until a state inspection has passed.

And one trap that catches owner-builders specifically: the rule that lets a utility energize **temporary construction power** ahead of an inspection is written for a licensed electrical contractor's permit only. A homeowner permit does not open that door.

WHAT IS IN THE KIT

The five documents

	Document	What it does for you
ID.1	The Building Permit Is Optional, the Trade Permits Are Not	Who, if anyone, enforces a building code on your parcel and how to tell; the three permits that apply regardless; the three owner exemptions with their three different tests; the temporary-power trap. Read this first.
ID.2	Permit Application Checklist	The code editions actually in force — and the 2024 update the Legislature rejected — the NEC amended downward, the energy table Idaho wrote itself, the trade fees as the rules set them, and the septic and well packages.
ID.3	Inspection Sequence & Clocks	The 10-business-day completeness clock, the 48-business-hour inspection rule with its self-help remedy on all four tracks, the trade inspection ladders the rules fix, and a log.
ID.4	Where to File Directory	How to tell an enforcing jurisdiction from one that is not, DOPL and its inspector list, the seven health districts by county, IDWR, two cities that run their own trade programs, and a page to record every office you confirmed.

The five documents

	Document	What it does for you
ID.5	Forms & Documents Index	Each document you will meet, named as the agency names it: the three DOPL homeowner permit applications and what you certify on them, the septic and well permits — and what Idaho never asks you for.

HOW TO USE IT

- **Start with ID.1.** Its first section settles whether any building code is enforced on your parcel. Nothing else sequences correctly until you know that — and unlike most states, Idaho publishes no list, so the kit gives you the verification step the statute itself created.
- **Buy the three trade permits regardless.** Electrical, plumbing and HVAC permits rest on three separate chapters of Title 54, none of which cares whether your county adopted a building code. A homeowner doing his own work still buys them. The electrical one is the one your utility will check.
- **Then deal with the septic system and the well.** Both are permitted by agencies the building code never touched — the health district and IDWR — and the septic separation distances constrain where the house can physically sit.
- **Keep ID.3 on the job** and record every inspection tag as it goes on — most of all if nobody is required to inspect the building itself. It is the only evidence you will have when you sell, refinance or insure.

How these facts were checked — and what this is not

Every Idaho claim here was read against its primary source in September 2026 — the Idaho Code on the Legislature's own site, the IDAPA rule chapters at adminrules.idaho.gov, DOPL's own forms and program pages, and the House Business Committee's minutes — and is cited where it appears. Where the answer genuinely depends on your city or county, the kit says so and gives you a line to write down what you confirmed. Not legal advice.